low to the emperor – now their spiritual master, or pir – putting their heads to his feet. He would raise them up, place a turban upon their heads, with a miniature portrait of himself pinned upon it, and give them an image of the sun.

Like every one of Akbar's major innovations, this, too, faced its share of resistance. Akbar had begun experimenting with taking on disciples before 1582. Abul Fazl, evidently a gatekeeper of the faith, describes himself discouraging a man called Fath Dost, whom he did not trust, from joining it. Akbar allowed it, however, declaring that 'becoming a disciple of this supplicant to God is a test of men, and brings out their internal qualities'. True enough: no sooner was Fath Dost inducted to the faith than he met the fate Abul Fazl felt he deserved. He was murdered during a drinking party.

It was after 1582, however, after Mirza Hakim's defeat, when, in Munis Faruqui's words, Akbar could afford to '[throw] all caution to the wind, abandoning even the slightest pretence of being an orthodox-minded Sunni-Muslim ruler',[51] that the emperor began initiating mansabdars as devotees in a systematic, though not always successful, way.

Not everyone, it seems, was as eager as Fath Dost to join Akbar's cult. Badauni describes a scene between the emperor, Birbar and two unwilling recruits, Qutubuddin Muhammad Khan and the Punjabi Shahbaz Khan. Both 'staunchly resisted', writes Badauni. Qutubuddin warned Akbar that his court would become a scandal, a laughing stock across the Islamic world. 'What would the kings of the West say, such as the Sultan of Constantinople, if they heard all this?'

Sardonically, Akbar asked whether the khan had come 'on a secret mission from Constantinople', or would he like to immigrate and 'become an honoured subject there'. The other reluctant convert, Shahbaz Khan, known for his temper, got 'excited' at this, and Birbar – 'that hellish dog' – took the opportunity to take a dig at Islam.

'Affairs became rather unpleasant,' writes Badauni, as one can well imagine, with Shahbaz threatening to kill Birbar, and Akbar wishing he could beat the khan's furious mouth 'with a slipper full of filth!'

Akbar would be piqued, naturally, at having his spiritual overlordship rebuffed; but he never forced it upon anyone. Badauni himself declined to acknowledge Akbar as his pir, and while he says that the emperor 'used